



THE PLAYER'S PATH

A Parent's Complete Guide to
Elite Football Development

**HOW TO HELP YOUR CHILD GET RECOGNISED,
DEVELOPED & SIGNED BY A PROFESSIONAL CLUB**

TALENT ID

What scouts really look
for

POSITION GUIDES

Position-specific
development

HOME TRAINING

Solo improvement plans

AGE PATHWAYS

U7 through U21
roadmaps

Insights drawn from FA, UEFA, PFSA & 360Scout frameworks

A LETTER TO EVERY FOOTBALL PARENT

You already know your child is special. You've seen it in training, in the garden, in the way they can't stop thinking about the game. But knowing your child has talent and knowing how to help them reach the highest levels are two very different things — and that gap is exactly what this guide is here to close.

Inside these pages, you'll find the same frameworks that professional clubs, elite scouts, and national associations use to identify, develop, and sign the next generation of footballers. We've drawn on guidance from the **FA's EPPP (Elite Player Performance Plan)**, **UEFA's Player Development Guidelines**, the **PFSA (Professional Football Scouts Association)**, and independent talent identification bodies like **360Scout** — and distilled it all into something you can actually use.

Whether your child is 7 and just discovering the game, or 17 and knocking on the door of a professional academy, this guide will show you what clubs are looking for, what your child can do to stand out, and — just as importantly — how you can support them the right way.

"The best thing a parent can do is create the environment. The player creates the player."

— Common philosophy across FA, PFSa & UEFA development frameworks

What This Guide Covers

- ✓ **Section 1 — How Clubs Really Identify Talent.** The 4-corner model, EPPP phases, and what scouts are genuinely watching.
- ✓ **Section 2 — Age-by-Age Development Pathways.** What's expected at every stage from U7 to U21.
- ✓ **Section 3 — Position-Specific Guides.** Detailed breakdowns for every position — what to develop and what to demonstrate.
- ✓ **Section 4 — Solo Training Plans.** Practical drills your child can do at home, in the park, or at the cage.
- ✓ **Section 5 — The Parent's Role.** How to support without hindering. The behaviours elite clubs love to see — in families.
- ✓ **Section 6 — Getting Noticed.** Trials, showcases, video, and how the pathway really works.

SECTION 1 · HOW CLUBS REALLY IDENTIFY TALENT

HOW PROFESSIONAL CLUBS FIND THEIR PLAYERS

The 4-Corner Model

Every major club and association — from grassroots academies to Premier League Category 1 clubs — uses a version of the **FA's 4-Corner Model** as their evaluation framework. It's not just about skill. Scouts assess your child across four interconnected areas simultaneously:

TECHNICAL	PHYSICAL	PSYCHOLOGICAL	SOCIAL
Ball control, passing, first touch, finishing	Speed, strength, agility, endurance	Decision-making, composure, resilience	Communication, leadership, teamwork

A crucial point for parents: **technical ability alone will not get your child signed**. Clubs at every level increasingly prioritise psychological and social traits — because skills can be taught, but attitude and character are much harder to develop.

The EPPP — Understanding the Academy System

The FA's **Elite Player Performance Plan (EPPP)** structures how academies operate across four phases. Understanding which phase your child is in helps you understand what's being prioritised in their development — and what you should be focusing on at home.

WHAT SCOUTS ARE ACTUALLY LOOKING FOR

Based on guidance from the **PFSA** and insights from leading talent identification agencies including **360Scout**, here are the key actions and traits scouts prioritise — beyond just whether a player is good with the ball:

- ✓ **Dominance in their phase of play.** Does the player consistently influence the game in their area? Not just occasionally — consistently.
- ✓ **Decision speed under pressure.** How quickly and correctly does the player decide when opponents close them down?
- ✓ **Resilience after mistakes.** Does the player bounce back? Scouts actively watch what happens in the two actions AFTER an error.
- ✓ **Off-the-ball movement.** What does the player do when they don't have the ball? This is a huge differentiator at elite levels.
- ✓ **Coachability during the game.** Does the player take on instructions? Can they adapt mid-match?
- ✓ **Physical presence relative to peers.** Not just size — agility, coordination, and athleticism relative to their age group.
- ✓ **Desire and intensity.** Work rate, pressing, tracking runs. Scouts call this 'wanting it' — and they can see it immediately.

*A note from the PFSA: Scouts rarely watch one player — they scan the whole pitch.
Your child needs to be doing the right things even when the ball is nowhere near them.*

SECTION 2 · AGE-BY-AGE DEVELOPMENT PATHWAYS

WHAT'S EXPECTED AT EVERY STAGE

U7 - U9 (Foundation Phase)*Focus: Exploration & love of the game***KEY DEVELOPMENT AREAS**

Comfortable with the ball in both feet — juggling, dribbling freely, close control. Willing to try things, make mistakes, and try again — creativity over caution. Basic movement literacy: running, jumping, changing direction, balance. Enjoyment is the #1 indicator — burnout at this age is a real risk.

HOW YOU CAN SUPPORT AT HOME

Play in multiple sports and environments — don't specialise yet. Never criticise performance — only celebrate effort and enjoyment. Encourage street football, free play, and unstructured ball time.

Scout Recognition Trigger: Clubs look for natural coordination, creativity, and a child who loves the ball.

U10 - U12 (Youth Development Phase — Early)*Focus: Technical foundations & positional awareness***KEY DEVELOPMENT AREAS**

Reliable first touch, accurate short passing, comfortable receiving under pressure. Beginning to understand positional responsibilities and team shape. 1v1 defending and attacking — reading the player in front of them. Introduction to game understanding: when to play forward, when to retain.

HOW YOU CAN SUPPORT AT HOME

Encourage watching football analytically — ask 'what did that player do well?' Begin position-specific solo training (see Section 4). Keep communication with coaches positive and open.

Scout Recognition Trigger: Technical consistency, game understanding, and coachability become key evaluation criteria.

U13 - U16 (Youth Development Phase — Critical)*Focus: Technical mastery, tactical identity & mental strength***KEY DEVELOPMENT AREAS****HOW YOU CAN SUPPORT AT HOME**

High technical standard under pressure — clean touches, weight of pass, execution. Clear positional identity and understanding of role within the team system. Mental resilience, confidence in big moments, and reading of the game. Physical development accelerates — athleticism, strength, and speed become visible. Leadership behaviours emerge — communication, responsibility, decision ownership.

This is the highest-pressure period for academy entry — stay calm and grounded. Support their rest and recovery — sleep, nutrition, and mental wellbeing matter enormously. Avoid comparing to other players — focus on their own development curve.

Scout Recognition Trigger: The most intensely scouted age band. Elite clubs actively recruit across grassroots and academies at U14.

U17 - U21 (Professional Development Phase)

Focus: Pro transition, tactical sophistication & performance

KEY DEVELOPMENT AREAS	HOW YOU CAN SUPPORT AT HOME
Consistent senior-level physical output — speed, power, endurance. Advanced tactical understanding of multiple systems and roles. Mental preparation for performance pressure — media, fans, high stakes. Professional habits: punctuality, nutrition, analysis, recovery routines. Loan experience, dual registration, first-team training exposure.	Your role now is emotional support, not footballing advice. Help them build a professional routine and mindset outside the game. Agent conversations begin here — seek reputable, FA-licensed representation.

Scout Recognition Trigger: Output and readiness for senior football. Character under pressure is the defining factor.

SECTION 3 · POSITION-SPECIFIC DEVELOPMENT GUIDES

EVERY POSITION. EVERY DETAIL.

One of the most powerful things you can give your child is **position-specific clarity** — knowing exactly what actions will get them noticed in their role, and exactly what to work on in every training session.

Goalkeeper (GK)	
WHAT SCOUTS WATCH FOR	SOLO HOME TRAINING DRILLS
Command of the penalty area — claiming crosses, organising defenders loudly. Distribution with both feet. Shot-stopping reflexes. 1v1 composure. Sweeper-keeper intelligence. Communication — talking constantly, leading the defensive line.	Wall rebounding — rapid reactions (10 mins daily). Footwork ladders. Tennis ball juggling. Video analysis of elite GKs. Cone work — lateral movement and angles. Kicking practice under fatigue.

Centre-Back (CB)	
WHAT SCOUTS WATCH FOR	SOLO HOME TRAINING DRILLS
Dominant aerial ability. Composure playing out from the back under pressure. Reading of the game — intercepting, anticipating. 1v1 defending — staying on feet. Leadership and vocal organisation. Recovery runs when beaten.	Heading against a wall or rebounder. Long passing practice — 30-50 yards. First touch drills for aerial balls. Sprint and recovery intervals. Passing patterns, both feet. Video study: Van Dijk, Rúben Dias.

Full-Back / Wing-Back (FB/WB)	
WHAT SCOUTS WATCH FOR	SOLO HOME TRAINING DRILLS
Defensive discipline — tracking wide forwards. Overlapping runs to create width. Crossing quality. 1v1 defending vs fast wingers. Inverted threat if applicable. Stamina to cover the full flank.	Interval running simulating overlaps. Crossing practice, both feet. 1v1 defending with a friend. Dribbling at pace through cones. Long passing and switching drills. Ball control at speed.

Defensive Midfielder (CDM / DM)**WHAT SCOUTS WATCH FOR**

Screening the back four. Winning the ball with timing and intelligence. Recycling possession under pressure. Reading the opponent's attacks. Transition leadership. Range of passing.

SOLO HOME TRAINING DRILLS

Passing wall work, switching angles. Control and turn drills. Positional study: Rodri, Casemiro. Press and cover shadow work. Sprint-to-control exercises. Endurance-focused gym work (U14+).

Central Midfielder (CM / Box-to-Box)**WHAT SCOUTS WATCH FOR**

Box-to-box engine — arriving late, tracking back. Technical quality in tight spaces. Decision-making speed. Pressing intelligence. Goal contributions. Leadership of transitions.

SOLO HOME TRAINING DRILLS

Rondo and possession games. Wall passing one-twos, both feet. Running with ball under pressure. Shooting from range for consistency. Interval conditioning. Scanning practice before receiving.

Attacking Midfielder (CAM / No.10)**WHAT SCOUTS WATCH FOR**

Movement between the lines. Link play with strikers and wide players. Final third creativity. Goal threat arriving late. Vision and through balls. Pressing from the front.

SOLO HOME TRAINING DRILLS

Tight space ball mastery, Coerver moves. Finishing after control, different angles. Through ball practice against a wall. Juggling with both feet. Video: De Bruyne, Özil, Bellingham.

Wide Forward / Winger (LW / RW)**WHAT SCOUTS WATCH FOR**

Pace and directness to beat a full-back 1v1. Crossing and cut-backs at the right moment. Cutting inside onto stronger foot. Pressing from wide. High work rate tracking back. Goal threat at the back post.

SOLO HOME TRAINING DRILLS

Dribbling at speed then shooting. Crossing practice, both feet. 1v1 attack practice vs cone/mannequin. Sprint training over 10-30 yards. Weaker foot development daily. Finishing cutting inside.

Striker / Centre-Forward (ST / CF)**WHAT SCOUTS WATCH FOR**

Finishing — composure, technique, variety across shot types.
Movement off the ball — runs in behind, near/far post. Hold-up play, shielding, bringing others into play. Pressing from the front.
Aerial threat. Link play with No.10 and wingers.

SOLO HOME TRAINING DRILLS

Finishing against a wall — first-time, volleys, half-volleys.
Movement and strike in one motion. Penalty and 1v1 practice under pressure. Heading practice — timing, direction, power.
Control and shoot from high balls. Video study: Haaland, Firmino, Kane.

SECTION 4 · SOLO HOME TRAINING — THE EXTRA 1%

WHAT YOUR CHILD DOES WHEN NO-ONE IS WATCHING

Elite players are not made on the training pitch alone. The players who reach the highest levels are those who **add extra sessions in their own time** — working on weaknesses, building physical attributes, and developing the small details that make a big difference come matchday.

The Weekly Solo Training Template

Use this as a starting guide — adapt it to your child's position. Quality always beats quantity. 20 focused minutes beats 90 distracted minutes.

DAY	SESSION FOCUS	DURATION	EXAMPLE ACTIVITIES
Monday	Technical — Ball Mastery	20–30 min	Juggling, ball mastery moves, first touch, weak foot
Tuesday	Rest / Light Movement	Optional	Walk, swim, yoga — active recovery
Wednesday	Position-Specific Work	30 min	Drills specific to their position (see Section 3)
Thursday	Speed & Agility	20 min	Ladder work, cone sprints, reaction exercises
Friday	Rest	—	Full rest before weekend fixtures
Saturday	Match / Team Training	—	Play. Enjoy. Compete.
Sunday	Finishing / Shooting	20–30 min	Goal practice, passing practice, creativity

Essential Equipment for Home Training

- ✓ **A ball** — the right size for the age group (size 3 for U8s, size 4 for U9–U13, size 5 for U14+)
- ✓ **Cones (6–12)** — for dribbling, passing patterns, and position markers
- ✓ **A rebounder / kickback net** — allows first-touch, passing, and shooting practice without a partner
- ✓ **Agility ladder** — 10–15 minutes of footwork daily improves coordination significantly
- ✓ **A wall or fencing** — a free passing partner. Drive passes hard and clean, repeatedly.
- ✓ **A football journal** — 2–3 things to improve after each session. Self-awareness is a superpower.

SECTION 5 · THE PARENT'S ROLE IN ELITE DEVELOPMENT

YOUR ROLE IS MORE IMPORTANT THAN YOU THINK

Research across the FA, UEFA, and independent sport psychology bodies consistently shows that **parental behaviour is one of the biggest factors** in whether a talented child fulfils their potential — or doesn't. The good news? The most powerful things you can do cost nothing.

What Elite Clubs Love to See in Parents

- ✓ **Positive sideline behaviour.** Applaud effort, not just results. Avoid coaching from the touchline — it confuses your child and conflicts with the coach's instructions.
- ✓ **Trust in the process.** Development is not linear. There will be bad games, periods without recognition, and moments of doubt. Your calm is contagious.
- ✓ **Questions, not conclusions.** After a game, ask 'What did you enjoy?' and 'What did you learn?' — not 'Why didn't you track back?'
- ✓ **Logistical excellence.** Clubs notice parents who are reliable, punctual, and organised. It reflects on the child.
- ✓ **A full life outside football.** Academies want well-rounded children who are happy, social, and academically engaged.

What Elite Clubs Worry About in Parents

- ✗ Shouting instructions or criticism during matches — even positively-intended coaching distracts players.
- ✗ Pressuring a child to train when injured, tired, or unwell.
- ✗ Comparing their child to teammates or rivals — publicly or at home.
- ✗ Disputing coaches' decisions openly in front of the child.
- ✗ Making football the child's entire identity — leading to anxiety around performance.
- ✗ Speaking negatively about the club, coach, or team to others, especially where the child can hear.

The car journey home is one of the most researched moments in youth sport psychology. Studies show that children most want parents to say: 'I loved watching you play today.' Nothing more. Let them lead any debrief — or enjoy the silence together.

SUPPORTING MENTAL WELLBEING IN ELITE SPORT

The pressure on talented young footballers is real and growing. Rejection from academies, being released, or losing form can be deeply painful for a child who has invested everything in the game. Here is what the research and practice guidelines recommend:

- ✓ Normalise failure and setbacks as part of the journey — the best players have all been released at some point.
- ✓ Ensure your child has interests, friendships, and identity completely outside football.
- ✓ Encourage open conversations about pressure, fear of failure, and self-doubt — these are normal.
- ✓ Know the signs of burnout: loss of enjoyment, irritability, physical complaints, withdrawal from the game.
- ✓ Consider working with a sports psychologist or mental performance coach if pressure becomes a pattern.

SECTION 6 · GETTING NOTICED — THE PRACTICAL PATHWAY

HOW THE RECOGNITION SYSTEM REALLY WORKS

Talent alone is rarely enough. The players who get picked up are those whose talent is **seen by the right people at the right time**. This section helps you understand how that happens.

How Scouts Find Players

- ✓ **Grassroots match-watching.** Category 1 club scouts regularly watch Sunday league and regional competitions.
- ✓ **Academy partnership networks.** Many professional clubs have affiliated development centres and feeder clubs.
- ✓ **Player recommendation.** Coaches, physios, and former players regularly recommend children to scouts.
- ✓ **Regional and national competitions.** County FA tournaments, regional cups, and national festivals attract intensive scouting.
- ✓ **Trials and open days.** Clubs periodically open trials — sign up for newsletters and monitor academy websites.
- ✓ **Digital and video.** Talent identification platforms (like the FA's own systems and 360Scout) allow players to be found via performance data and video.

Creating a Player Highlight Video

A well-made highlight video is now a legitimate and effective tool for attracting club interest at U14 and above. Think of it as your child's sporting CV.

VIDEO ELEMENT	GUIDANCE
Length	2–4 minutes maximum. Scouts will not watch more than this.
Opening	Best action in the first 30 seconds. Lead with the strongest material.
Content	Clips showing position-specific skills: technical quality, decisions, movement, effort.
Variety	Show different types of play — in possession, out of possession, set pieces.
Context	Include date, age group, competition level. Show the level they're playing at.
Quality	Good picture quality. Avoid shaky phone footage — a tripod costs very little.
Narration	No music or commentary needed. Let the football speak.
Contact	Add your email and a short bio at the end (name, DOB, position, club, height).

TRIAL DAY — WHAT TO TELL YOUR CHILD

- ✓ **Be yourself, not the version you think they want to see.** Scouts want to assess the real player — not an anxious, over-trying version.
- ✓ **Communication is scouted too.** Talk to teammates, organise, encourage. Clubs notice it.
- ✓ **Effort is always within your control.** If nervous about technical performance, double your work rate. Commitment is always visible.
- ✓ **Express yourself.** Don't play safe to avoid mistakes. Try things. Scouts want to see character, not caution.
- ✓ **It's one day, not the whole story.** Many successful professionals were released from academies multiple times before being signed. Perspective is everything.

IMPORTANT: SAFEGUARDING & REGULATIONS

All legitimate club approaches must go through proper FA-regulated channels. Be cautious of any individual or organisation that asks for payment to secure a trial or promises guaranteed entry to a professional academy. Reputable clubs and licensed agents do not operate this way. Always check FA registration for any agent or scouting organisation your child is connected with.

ONE LAST THING

Every elite player was once just a child who loved kicking a ball. The path from that child to a professional footballer is long, winding, and full of moments of doubt — for both player and parent. But it is walked every single year by young people just like your child.

The most important thing you can do is not find the perfect academy, secure the perfect trial, or buy the best equipment. The most important thing you can do is **make sure your child still loves football**. That love — unforced, genuine, and joyful — is the engine of everything.

Everything else in this guide — the scouting frameworks, the position-specific drills, the training plans — is a toolkit to be used in service of that love. Pick what's useful. Leave what isn't. Trust your child. Trust the process.

*The goal is not just to produce a professional footballer.
The goal is to raise a confident, resilient, passionate young person
who happens to play football at the highest level they can.*

Quick Reference Resources

- ✓ **The FA's Academy Finder:** thefa.com — search for EPPP-registered academies
- ✓ **PFSa (Professional Football Scouts Association):** thepfsa.co.uk
- ✓ **360Scout:** 360scout.co.uk — independent talent identification and player profiling
- ✓ **UEFA Player Development:** uefa.com/insideuefa/football-development
- ✓ **Coerver Coaching:** coerver.co.uk — widely used technical development methodology

This guide has been compiled from publicly available frameworks published by the FA, UEFA, PFSa, and independent talent identification bodies. It is intended as an informational resource for parents and is not affiliated with any club, academy, or organisation.